all around him. Instead, according to Palit, ‘without waiting for preliminaries, Kaul launched into a dramatized blow-by-blow account of events subsequent to the fall of Walong and the part he had played in them: details of 11 Infantry Brigade’s withdrawal along both banks of the Lohit; supply dropping missions for the withdrawing troops; ‘rescue’ missions by helicopter, in one of which Kaul had personally landed ‘amidst sporadic enemy fire’ and offered to evacuate the Brigade Commander (quite an unprofessional procedure, in my opinion, because the brigade would have been left in the lurch without a commander). ‘The Brigade Commander, stout-heartedly, declined the offer.’

For a full thirty minutes, the *Official History of the 1962 War* records, the ‘situation in the Lohit Frontier Division was discussed’. Neither Thapar nor Sen tried to stop him. Every time Palit tried to interrupt Kaul ‘he would take off on a description of some other hair-raising episode of the Lohit battle, jumping up and down excitedly at the wall map’. Eventually, unable to contain himself, Palit walked over to Kaul and gripped his arm. ‘Bijji bhai,’ he said firmly, ‘forget Walong, the crisis is in Kameng. Your 4th Division is collapsing.’

‘What?’ he exclaimed, suddenly alarmed. ‘What are you talking about?’

Palit then gave him a rundown of what had been happening at Nuranang and Se-la since the morning. Se-la could hold out, perhaps not indefinitely, but surely for at least a week or ten days, but someone had to firmly tell Anant Pathania that pulling out was not an option. In his absence no one had done that and they were now awaiting his arrival so that as the corps commander, he could take that decision once and for all.

It was perhaps the defining moment of the Se-la battle. Palit, assertive and somewhat agitated, yet cool and articulate, had to succeed for the brigade and the division’s survival. But just then General Pran Thapar ordered Palit to go and check on the status of 82 Infantry Brigade which was being rushed to 2 Division from Rajasthan. The chief told Palit to make sure the orders were to airlift the brigade and not to send it by train.

During the next thirty minutes, Kaul spoke to both Pathania and Gurbax Singh on the telephone to ascertain for himself the situation in Se-la and Bomdila. While Thapar had relapsed into a brooding silence, Sen was of the opinion that Pathania, as the man on the spot, was best suited to take appropriate action. As per official records, Kaul spoke to Pathania at least twice in quick succession.